

LIVE



NEWSPAPER 20th September, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

38th WEEK



REFERENDUM OF IRAQI KURDS

UPSC CSE – GS I

GS I... REGIONALISM.



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS ... DISCUSSION

20th SEPTEMBER, 2017

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The Kurdish vote

With Iraqi Kurds still firm on a referendum, Baghdad must keep tensions from escalating

Iraqi Kurdistan's decision to go ahead with a proposed independence referendum, despite strong opposition both from within and outside Iraq, has created a regional political storm in West Asia. The Iraqi Supreme Court has already asked the Kurdistan Regional Government to suspend the vote, scheduled for September 25, till its legality is settled. Iraqi Prime Minister Haider al-Abadi has threatened to use force if the referendum turns violent. The Turkish government has ordered a military drill on the Iraqi border, while Iran has also issued a warning. Such opposition is largely driven by fears that a 'yes' vote in the referendum, which is almost certain, would enhance the nationalist aspirations of Kurds living in other countries and further destabilise the region. Besides Iraq, Kurds, the fourth largest ethnic group in West Asia but without a state, are scattered in various countries, including Turkey, Iran and Syria. In Turkey, Kurdish rebels are involved in a protracted civil war, while in Syria they have established a regional government. They are all keenly awaiting the outcome of the Iraqi vote. A 'yes' vote doesn't necessarily mean that Iraqi Kurdistan would immediately break away from Iraq. Both the regional government in Erbil and the federal government in Baghdad are not ready for that. But the Kurdish Regional Government, led by Masoud Barzani, wants to send a message to Baghdad as well as the outside world that its aspirations for independence are genuine and have popular resonance.

For generations, Iraqi Kurds have been at the receiving end in the dysfunctional relationship between Baghdad and Erbil. Kurds had been brutally repressed until the regional government was formed following the first Gulf War of 1991. Since then, they have exercised autonomy and built institutions for self-governance, but Kurdistan has remained part of Iraq. Now, Mr. Barzani, who will step down as the President of the regional government after the November 1 elections, is looking to begin the process for restructuring Erbil-Baghdad ties. Baghdad should see this as an opportunity to address the Kurdish question. In recent years, both Baghdad and Erbil cooperated in the fight against the Islamic State. Now that the IS threat has been largely contained, both sides can refocus their energies on settling the dispute between themselves. Though independence remains the proclaimed goal of Iraqi Kurdistan, Mr. Barzani himself has often signalled compromise. He once proposed a confederation, a united state in which Iraq and Kurdistan could co-exist, sharing resources and a vision on foreign and security policies. Baghdad chose to ignore such proposals. With the push for the referendum, Kurds are trying to change the status quo. Federal dialogue is essential, for it is neither in Baghdad's nor the Kurds' interest to jeopardise the relative calm in Iraq's northeast, or to deepen sectarian fault lines.

2 The Kurdish vote

THE  HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Date : 20th September, 2017

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2 The Kurdish vote

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KURDISTAN

- Official borders of the Region of Iraqi Kurdistan
- Territory controlled by Iraqi Kurdistan
- Territory claimed by Iraqi Kurdistan

SYRIA

IRAQ

IRAN

KUWAIT

JORDAN

KURDS AND IRAQ



- 1** In Iraq, Kurds are estimated between 17% to 20%. Roughly they are around 6 million.
- 2** They are in total 30 to 40 million, live in a compact area, which stretches from Syria to Iran, Iraq to Turkey and also into the States of former Soviet Caucasus region.
- 3** The 2005 Iraq Constitution recognises an autonomous Kurdistan run by the Kurdistan Regional Government.



Saddam Hussein
Former President of Iraq



LONG STRUGGLE FOR KURDS

- 1 Kurds of Iraq came under the British colonial rule after the defeat of the Ottoman empire in 1918.
- 2 Kurdish leaders subsequently launched a series of rebellions against British and subsequent Iraqi rule.
- 3 They were put down ruthlessly, when Saddam Hussein attacked the Kurds with chemical weapons in some places. Most notorious one is the attack on the town of Halabja in 1988.
- 4 In due course of time, Kurdish leaders and their Peshmerga armed forces consolidated their hold in the North, after Iraqi forces withdrew and provided the basis for 2005 constitutional settlement.



WHAT CHANGED DURING THE PAST FEW YEARS?

- 1 There are several sectarian tensions within Iraq from 2013 onwards.
- 2 Now, the challenge posed by Islamic State makes unity of Iraq under severe threat.
- 3 Now, Finally the Iraqi Kurdistan is going for referendum.

WHY IS IT CREATING STORM IN WEST ASIA?



- 1 If 'yes' vote is there in the referendum, this would enhance the nationalist aspirations of Kurds living in other adjacent countries and may lead to destabilisation.
- 2 Kurds are the fourth largest ethnic group in West Asia, but without a state.
- 3 In Syria, they have established a regional Government and in Turkey, Kurdish rebels are involved in a protracted civil war.
- 4 Already, West Asia is having number of problems and if Kurds separate from Iraq, then it may be another blow in the already contentious West Asia region.



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